WEEKLY JOURNAL DIGEST

Weekly journal digest for 2026-09-07 to 2026-09-12

Curated articles in political communication and computational social science.

SPECIAL ISSUE UPDATES

Calls checked: 2026-09-12.

Manual calls omitted pending renewed official-page verification: Public Relations Review.

Thematic Issue: Revisiting the Nexus of Science, Politics, Media, and Publics Amid Digital and Societal Transformations
Media and Communication | Deadline within 14 days | call for papers
Deadline: 2026-09-15
Official call / submission details

Thematic Issue: Trust, Misinformation, and Institutional Communication in High-Trust or High-Control Societies
Media and Communication | Deadline within 14 days | call for papers
Deadline: 2026-09-15
Official call / submission details

SUMMARY

This Saturday edition covers September 7-12 and centers on democratic rhetoric, political persuasion, news bias, community information, and the use of language models in public reasoning. The strongest papers combine direct communication questions with reusable computational or research-design tools.

You may have received two September 7 emails because the first was sent before that collection window closed; the second completed the same edition. Saturday delivery now aligns collection and sending, so each future email represents a distinct Monday-Saturday edition.

The curated list keeps every substantive article from the dedicated communication and political science journals and eight general-science papers closely aligned with COMAP interests. Previously delivered August 31-September 6 papers are excluded from this edition to keep the reading list clean and avoid repeat content.

HIGHLIGHTS

The Language of Democratic Resilience and Decline: A Comparative Study of Politicians' Communication on Facebook in Sweden and Hungary

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-11

Why it matters · Compares how politicians in Sweden and Hungary communicate democratic resilience and decline on Facebook, directly connecting elite platform rhetoric to democratic backsliding.

Open article →

The Media Bias Detector: A framework for annotating and analyzing the news

SCIENCE ADVANCES · 2026-09-11

Why it matters · Introduces a scalable LLM-assisted system for measuring selection and framing bias across 140,000 news articles, with an explorable dataset for computational media research.

Open article →

Exposure to "connective language" in political Facebook posts leads to more enjoyment and less psychological reactance

JOURNAL OF COMPUTER-MEDIATED COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-09

Why it matters · A preregistered experiment with 2,032 participants finds that connective language can reduce reactance to disagreeable political posts, although it does not increase visible engagement.

Open article →

Do Emotional Ads Persuade? Evidence from Real-Time Campaign Advertising Experiments

POLITICAL COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-09

Why it matters · Real-time experiments with 48 campaign ads and roughly 28,000 participants show that emotional reactions are poor proxies for persuasion in polarized elections.

Open article →

Plausible nonsense and deliberative reasoning: Benchmarking LLMs against human judgment

PROCEEDINGS OF THE NATIONAL ACADEMY OF SCIENCES · 2026-09-09

Why it matters · Benchmarks 60 language models on public reason-giving and finds that plausible prose often masks weak alignment with human deliberative judgment, a key limit for AI-assisted governance.

Open article →

Loneliness and the local news environment

JOURNAL OF COMMUNICATION · 2026-09-08

Why it matters · Links the erosion of local journalism to loneliness using state-level media data and a nationally representative survey, extending media-effects research to community belonging.

Open article →

Designing multisite studies for external validity: Site selection via synthetic purposive sampling

AMERICAN JOURNAL OF POLITICAL SCIENCE · 2026-09-07

Why it matters · Offers a statistically grounded method for choosing diverse sites in multi-site causal studies, helping researchers design evidence that travels beyond a single context.

Open article →

Causal evidence that language models use confidence to drive behaviour

NATURE MACHINE INTELLIGENCE · 2026-09-07

Why it matters · Provides causal evidence that language models use internal confidence signals when deciding whether to answer or abstain, with implications for autonomous agents and uncertainty-aware research tools.

Open article →

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COLLECTION SNAPSHOT

TOTAL COLLECTED CANDIDATES	NEW THIS WEEK CANDIDATES	PREVIOUS WEEK CATCH-UP CANDIDATES
408	**164**	**207**
LATE ADDITIONS CANDIDATES		
37		

Curated digest below: 15 new, 0 catch-up, 0 late additions

The candidate counts are after automatic source filters and before manual relevance review.

All 17 article sources completed successfully. Catch-up and late-addition candidates were already included in the corrected September 7 delivery and are omitted here to prevent duplicate reading.

FULL CURATED DIGEST

New This Week

American Journal of Political Science

Designing multisite studies for external validity: Site selection via synthetic purposive sampling

2026-09-07 · DOI 10.1111/AJPS.70070

Naoki Egami; Diana Da In Lee

Center for the Study of Democratic Institutions Vanderbilt University Nashville Tennessee USA; Department of Political Science and Statistics and Data Science Center Massachusetts Institute of Technology Cambridge Massachusetts USA

Abstract. Abstract Multisite/context studies have become popular strategies to address the most common and challenging external validity concerns about contexts. Under such studies, scholars conduct causal studies in each site and evaluate whether findings generalize across sites. Despite the potential, there has been little guidance on the fundamental research design question-how should we select sites for external validity? Existing approaches have challenges: random sampling of sites is often infeasible, while the current practice of purposive sampling is suboptimal without statistical guarantees. We propose synthetic purposive sampling (SPS), which optimally selects diverse sites for external validity. SPS combines ideas of purposive sampling and the synthetic control method-it selects diverse sites such that nonselected sites are well approximated by the weighted average of the selected sites. We illustrate its general applicability using both experimental and observational studies. Overall, this paper offers a new statistical foundation to design multisite studies for external validity.

Read article →

Journal of Communication

Loneliness and the local news environment

2026-09-08 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG016

Danny Hayes; Anusha Trivedi

George Washington University Department of Political Science, , Washington, DC,

Abstract. Abstract Recent research suggests that changes to the media environment have contributed to loneliness in the United States. This work focuses on smartphones and social media, with the decline of local news receiving little attention. We argue that local news promotes social well-being by informing residents about their communities, fostering attachment and a sense of belonging that can reduce loneliness. We provide evidence in two studies. First, using state-level data and multiple measures of news availability, we show that loneliness is higher in states with fewer options for local news. Second, we find in a nationally representative survey that people who rarely consume local journalism report greater loneliness than regular local news consumers. There is some evidence that the relationship is strongest in rural areas, which have experienced severe declines in local news access. We conclude by proposing a research agenda to further explore how community news may support social well-being.

Read article →

Looking good, fitting in: co-trajectories of appearance- and friendship-related identity distress and positive online self-presentation in adolescence

2026-09-08 · DOI 10.1093/JOC/JQAG015

Gaelle Vanhoffelen; Lara Schreurs; Laura Vandenbosch

Media Psychology Lab, Department of Communication Sciences, Faculty of Social Sciences, KU Leuven , Leuven,; Research Foundation Flanders (FWO-Vlaanderen) , Brussels,

Abstract. Abstract Adolescence is a critical period for identity development, often accompanied by identity distress. Simultaneously, adolescents are also preoccupied with presenting themselves as positive as possible on social media, which may reflect and reinforce identity distress. Yet, the dynamic associations between adolescents' identity distress and positive online self-presentations remain unexplored. Accordingly, this three-wave panel study among adolescents from Belgium, France, and Slovenia (N = 1,697; Mage = 15.14, SDage = 1.78, 57.2% girls) used Latent Class Growth Analysis to identify distinct co-trajectories of identity distress and positive online self-presentation in the domains of friendship and appearance over one year. The findings showed that identity distress and positive self-presentations can follow maladaptive, (high risk) adaptive, or stable co-trajectories over time, depending on the identity domain, adolescents' demographic, and social media use characteristics. In doing so, the study provides novel evidence on the heterogeneous co-development of adolescents' identity distress and online self-presentation.

Read article →

Journal of Computer-Mediated Communication

Exposure to "connective language" in political Facebook posts leads to more enjoyment and less psychological reactance

2026-09-09 · DOI 10.1093/JCMC/ZMAG020

Gina M Masullo; Shuting Yao; Zhi Lin; Josephine Lukito; Ashwin Rajadesingan; Natalie J Stroud

Center for Media Engagement, The University of Texas at Austin , Austin, TX,; Department of Communication Studies, The University of Texas at Austin , Austin, TX,; Digital Democracy Center, The University of Southern Denmark , Odense, Syddanmark,; School of Journalism and Media, The University of Texas at Austin , Austin, TX,

Abstract. Abstract In this preregistered study, we experimentally tested (n = 2,032) whether "connective language"-language that expresses openness to others' perspectives and humility in presenting one's viewpoints-reduces psychological reactance to disagreeable political messages. Compared with non-connective Facebook posts, a single connective post reduced expressed reactance, counter-arguing, and perceived threat to one's freedom. Connective posts also elicited fewer negative and positive emotions. Participants found connective posts more enjoyable and they spent more time reading them, although these posts were slightly longer. However, post type did not affect behavioral engagement, such as liking or replying. Our findings suggest that social media platforms should optimize their algorithms to surface connective language, and the public should consider adopting this type of language.

Read article →

Nature

Why we need an International Panel on Inequality

2026-09-09 · DOI 10.1038/D41586-026-02806-9

Joseph E. Stiglitz; Adriana E. Abdenur; Winnie Byanyima; Jayati Ghosh; Imraan Valodia; Wanga Zembe-Mkabile

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Nature Communications

Active inference and artificial reasoning

2026-09-08 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77209-5

Karl Friston; Lancelot Da Costa; Alexander Tschantz; Conor Heins; Christopher L. Buckley; Tim Verbelen; Thomas Parr

Abstract. Abstract This paper considers the sampling of outcomes that provide the greatest amount of information about the structure of underlying world models. This generalisation furnishes a principled approach to structure learning, and specifically rule discovery, under a plausible set of generative models or hypotheses. In active inference, policies-i.e., combinations of actions-are selected based on their expected free energy, which comprises expected information gain and value. Information gain corresponds to the Kullback-Leibler divergence between predictive posteriors with, and without, the consequences of action. Posteriors over models can be evaluated quickly and efficiently using Bayesian Model Reduction, based upon accumulated posterior beliefs about model parameters. The ensuing information gain can then be used to select actions that disambiguate among alternative models, in the spirit of optimal experimental design. We illustrate this kind of active selection or reasoning using partially observed discrete models; namely, a three-ball paradigm used previously to describe artificial insight and aha moments via (synthetic) introspection or sleep. We focus on the sample efficiency afforded by seeking outcomes that resolve the greatest uncertainty about the world model, under which outcomes are generated.

Read article →

Near-term increased exposure to political risk for African power trades

2026-09-08 · DOI 10.1038/S41467-026-77362-X

Teresa Bonserio; Angelo Carlino; Matteo Giuliani; Andrea Castelletti

Abstract. Conflicts and socio-political instability plague electricity security in many African countries, hindering a transition to a net-zero emissions energy system. Established large-scale energy system planning approaches, relying on least-cost optimization models, regularly neglect the impact of political turmoil on energy security. This study assesses how six cost-optimal energy transition strategies for Africa might be affected by future socio-political instability and power trade volumes through a measure of power trade-related political risk. Our findings indicate that the most vulnerable period for Africa is the first half of the 2020-2030 decade, with socio-political risk hotspots in Western, Southern, and Central-Eastern Africa. Different socio-demographic, climatic and hydrological regime assumptions influence the distribution of socio-political risk across different regions, as countries uniquely adapt to future scenarios. These findings underscore the crucial need to integrate socio-political factors into energy systems planning, ensuring that transition strategies are flexible and cognizant of the involved risks. This analysis of the future African power sector finds political risk to electricity trade will peak in the near-term, hitting Western, Southern, and Central-Eastern Africa hardest, calling for including political stability in energy planning.

Read article →

Nature Human Behaviour

Effects of a randomized controlled trial of unconditional cash transfers on epigenetic measures of ageing and cognition in children and mothers

2026-09-08 · DOI 10.1038/S41562-026-02568-4

Laurel Raffington; Yayouk E. Willems; Jessica F. Sperber; Sepideh Zarandooz; Molly A. Costanzo; Daniel A. Notterman; Colter Mitchell; Elliot M. Tucker-Drob; Greg J. Duncan; Nathan A. Fox; Lisa A. Gennetian; Katherine A. Magnuson; Sonya V. Troller-Renfree; Hirokazu Yoshikawa; Elisabeth B. Binder; K. Paige Harden; Kimberly G. Noble

Abstract. Abstract Here we present epigenetic findings from a randomized controlled trial studying the impact of unconditional cash gifts of US$333 per month (children n = 313; mothers n = 329) or US$20 per month (children n = 423; mothers n = 448) to US mothers with low income during their child's first four years of life. Salivary DunedinPACE-pace of aging, a DNA-methylation predictor of healthy lifespan, and Epigenetic- g , a DNA-methylation biomarker of cognition, were preregistered as secondary outcomes (clinical trial identifier NCT03593356). As hypothesized, high-cash compared with low-cash gifts caused a 0.17 s.d. (95% confidence interval 0.32 to 0.01, P = 0.037) difference in children's DunedinPACE. We found no evidence supporting our hypothesis that higher cash gifts increased children's Epigenetic- g , although it did correlate with children's brain activity. There was no evidence that the cash gift had an impact on these epigenetic indices in mothers. These findings show a detectable impact of monthly unconditional cash received through early childhood on epigenetic indices of 4-year-old children in families with low income. Whether this epigenetic effect persists and how it may relate to behavioural and health outcomes remains unknown.

Read article →

Nature Machine Intelligence

Causal evidence that language models use confidence to drive behaviour

2026-09-07 · DOI 10.1038/S42256-026-01293-X

Dharshan Kumaran; Nathaniel Daw; Simon Osindero; Petar Velickovic; Viorica Patraucean

Abstract. Metacognition-assessing the quality of one's own cognitive performance-guides adaptive behaviour across species. Confidence signals can be extracted from language model outputs, yet a fundamental question remains: do models actually use these signals to decide whether to answer or abstain? Here we developed a four-phase paradigm. Phase 1 elicited baseline confidence without an abstention option. Phase 2 showed that large language models apply an implicit threshold to internal confidence when abstaining, with confidence effect sizes roughly an order of magnitude larger than alternative mechanisms. Phase 3 provided causal evidence via activation steering: boosting or suppressing confidence correspondingly decreased or increased abstention, with mediation analysis confirming confidence redistribution as the primary mechanism. Phase 4 instructed models to abstain at different confidence levels and showed they adjusted their behaviour accordingly, indicating they read out and act on confidence to set abstention policies. Critically, verbal confidence-an explicit self-evaluation from a separate forward pass-independently predicted abstention across all models despite being less discriminatory of correctness, and activation decoding showed both measures (that is, token log probabilities and verbal confidence) are lossy read-outs of a richer internal representation. Together, these results suggest that abstention is captured by the joint operation of a multidimensional internal confidence representation and threshold-based policies-consistent with structured metacognitive control in large language models-a capacity of growing importance as models transition to autonomous agents that must recognize their own uncertainty. Kumaran et al. show that large language models making decisions on when to answer a question or abstain from answering can be influenced by boosting or suppressing confidence signals in the model.

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Political Analysis

Get Out the Volunteer: Encouraging Diverse Political Party Activism

2026-09-09 · DOI 10.1017/PAN.2026.10053

Jonne Kamphorst; Horacio Larreguy

ITAM; Sciences Po Paris

Abstract. Abstract Political parties in advanced democracies face a dual challenge: fewer citizens are willing to volunteer, and those who remain active are disproportionately older and male. This is troubling given the central role that volunteers play in campaigns and party processes. Whether party leaders can recruit a larger and more diverse activist base remains an open question. We partnered with a major party in the Netherlands and conducted two field experiments before the 2021 general and 2022 municipal elections, targeting over 35,000 party members. The party randomized whether members received a personal call, an email or both. Results show that calls-where members could voice their opinions-increased volunteer sign-up rates (83% in Study 1 and 361% in Study 2), especially among younger members. By contrast, emails had no effect. These findings clarify mixed evidence in the literature, suggesting that voice opportunities are key to expanding and diversifying the activist base.

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Political Communication

The Language of Democratic Resilience and Decline: A Comparative Study of Politicians' Communication on Facebook in Sweden and Hungary

2026-09-11 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2727043

Xenia Farkas; Simon Lindgren

Umea University, Director of DIGSUM; Umea University, Umea, Sweden; Research Fellow at ELTE Centre for Social Sciences

Abstract. Abstract unavailable.

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Do Emotional Ads Persuade? Evidence from Real-Time Campaign Advertising Experiments

2026-09-09 · DOI 10.1080/10584609.2026.2726266

John Murphy; Alexander Coppock; Seth J. Hill; Lynn Vavreck

Northwestern University; University of California; University of California, San Diego

Abstract. We evaluate whether campaign advertisements that generate larger emotional reactions also generate larger persuasive effects in contemporary elections. We analyze 29 weeks of experiments conducted during the 2016 U.S. presidential campaign, in which 48 authentic campaign ads were tested in real time, often within days of their debut. The ads and a placebo were randomly assigned to approximately 28,000 subjects. We find that campaign ads reliably move emotions, albeit in largely partisan ways, with comparatively muted reactions among independents. Critically, however, these emotional reactions do not predict the magnitude of an ad's effect on candidate favorability, vote intention, policy preferences, or turnout intention. Our results cast doubt on emotion-based accounts of advertising persuasion in polarized elections and caution practitioners against using self-reported emotional reactions as a measure of message effectiveness.

Read article →

Proceedings of the National Academy of Sciences

A role for self-regulatory control in the absence of ingroup preference

2026-09-09 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2600311123

Samuel A. W. Klein; Tessa E. S. Charlesworth; Daniel W. Heck; Mahzarin R. Banaji; Jeffrey W. Sherman

Department of Psychology, Columbia University; Department of Psychology, Harvard University; Department of Psychology, University of California; Department of Psychology, University of Marburg; Kellogg School of Management, Northwestern University

Abstract. One of psychology's most ubiquitous findings is that of robust ingroup preference, an explicitly stated human preference for the groups to which we belong. The advent of implicit measures of social cognition introduced a paradoxical result: Compared to members of higher-status groups, members of lower-status groups often show no implicit ingroup preference, sometimes even showing outgroup preference, a result rarely observed on explicit measures. Prevailing theories have provided macro-level accounts, often in terms of system-justifying tendencies, but the various cognitive processes that could produce such an absence of ingroup preference among lower-status groups have not been directly decomposed. In this paper, we address this gap via formal process modeling applied to data from 5.7 million respondents collected across 16 years and 6 social categories. We find that, among lower-status groups, ingroup-affirming evaluations are accompanied by more pronounced self-regulatory control than outgroup-affirming evaluations, a regulatory asymmetry absent among higher-status groups. For example, evaluations affirming Black and overweight ingroups were accompanied by heightened self-regulatory control, whereas a comparable self-regulatory pattern was not observed for evaluations affirming White and nonoverweight ingroups. The evidence points to a previously unrecognized role for self-regulatory control in the absence of ingroup preference, suggesting that the cognitive imprint of social hierarchies may extend beyond evaluative associations to the regulatory processes that govern their expression.

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Plausible nonsense and deliberative reasoning: Benchmarking LLMs against human judgment

2026-09-09 · DOI 10.1073/PNAS.2600126123

Francesco Veri; Gustavo Kreia Umbelino

Centre for Democracy Studies Aarau, University of Zurich

Abstract. Large Language Models (LLMs) are entering democratic contexts as instruments of governance, where the challenges at hand are ill-structured, marked by ambiguity and contestation. Ill-structured democratic problems demand more than factual precision; they call for intersubjective reasoning: context-sensitive judgments that others can understand and publicly accept. Using the Deliberative Reason Index (DRI), this study evaluates 60 LLMs against human deliberation across nine policy scenarios. Only four models consistently exceed the permutation-based null benchmark for alignment with human patterns of reason-giving. Most models fall short: their reason-preference structures rarely clear this threshold, even though their outputs can still appear coherent and persuasive. Yet outputs can appear reasonable even when this alignment is absent. The observed gap between surface plausibility and deliberative coherence urges caution: deploying LLMs in governance contexts requires prior assessment of their deliberative reasoning capacity, not just their surface outputs.

Read article →

Science Advances

The Media Bias Detector: A framework for annotating and analyzing the news

2026-09-11 · DOI 10.1126/SCIADV.AEA7456

Samar Haider; Amir Tohidi; Jenny S. Wang; Timothy Dorr; David M. Rothschild; Chris Callison-Burch; Duncan J. Watts

Annenberg School for Communication, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA, USA.; Department of Computer and Information Science, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA, USA.; Department of Operations, Information, and Decisions, University of Pennsylvania, Philadelphia, PA, USA.; Harvard Business School, Boston, MA, USA.; Microsoft Research, New York, NY, USA.

Abstract. News organizations introduce bias into their coverage via the choices they make about which topics to cover (or ignore) and how to frame the issues they do decide to cover. Here, we introduce the Media Bias Detector, a scalable computational framework that integrates large language models (LLMs) with near-real-time news scraping to extract structured annotations, including political lean, tone, topics, article type, and major events, across hundreds of articles per day. We quantify these dimensions of coverage at the sentence level, the article level, and the publisher level, expanding the ways in which researchers can analyze selection and framing bias in the modern news landscape. We also release an interactive web platform for convenient exploration of these data and an accompanying dataset covering more than 140,000 articles published in 2024 by 10 prominent publishers. Last, we present some results derived from this dataset that illustrate how the MBD can uncover correlates of bias in news coverage.

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